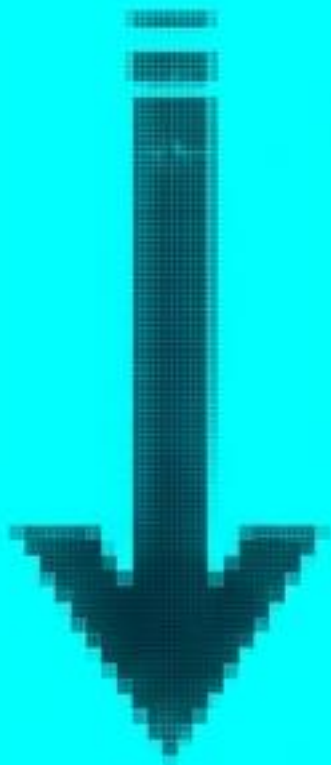


The Breakfast Club: A Study in Identity

Subtext: Exploring stereotypes, coming of age, and the ultimate 80s teen movie.





Eight Hours in Saturday Detention



Five teenagers from different high school groups are forced to spend a Saturday in detention.



Supervised by the strict Vice Principal Vernon, they must write a 1,000-word essay about who they think they are.



Over eight hours, they argue, talk, break rules, and realize they share common struggles.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS AT 7:00 AM



AT 7:00 AM, THE STUDENTS ONLY SEE EACH OTHER AS THESE SIMPLE, ONE-DIMENSIONAL LABELS.

What Lies Beneath the Labels

Character	The Crime	The Reality
Brian	Brought a flare gun to school	Crushing academic pressure and fear of failure.
Andrew	Bullied another student	Intense pressure from his father to be an aggressive winner.
Claire	Skipped school to shop	Used as a weapon in her parents' arguments.
Bender	Pulled the fire alarm	Suffers physical and verbal abuse at home.
Allison	Volunteered (nothing else to do)	Completely ignored and neglected by her family.

The "Looking-Glass" Identity

The teenagers in the film act out the roles programmed into them by their environment.



Are you who you want to be, or are you just who your parents, teachers, and friends expect you to be?

Insight: The detention forces them to step outside the looking-glass of high school society and examine their true selves.

The Fear of Growing Up

- The movie highlights a massive generational divide.
- The teenagers are terrified of losing their individuality and becoming just like their parents.



When you grow up,
your heart dies.
— Allison

Do you think Allison is right about the adult world?

Behind the Scenes at Shermer High



The Library: It wasn't a real library! The massive set was built entirely inside a high school gymnasium in Illinois.

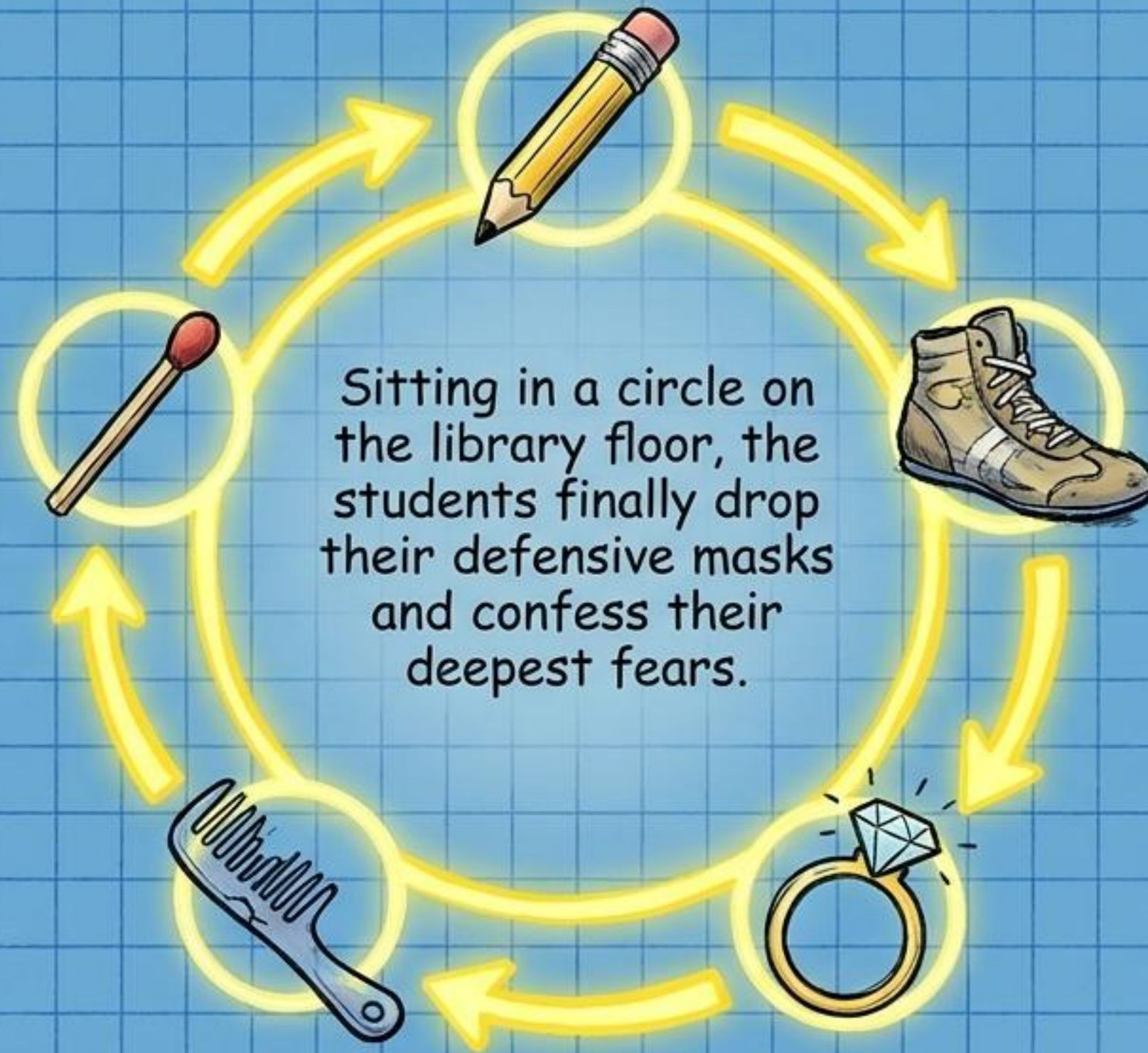


The Poster: The famous promotional photo of the cast huddled together was shot by legendary photographer Annie Leibovitz.



The Song: The band Simple Minds originally said no to recording the movie's famous theme song before changing their minds.

Unscripted Honesty in the Circle



Movie Magic:

Director John Hughes did not write the exact dialogue for this crucial scene. He told the actors their characters' motivations and let them completely ad-lib (improvise) the conversation to make the emotions feel 100% real.

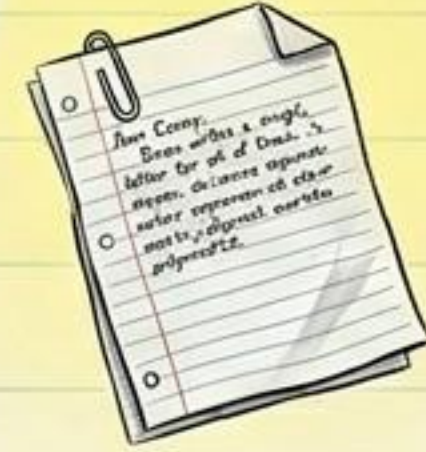
Symbols of Connection



A Diamond Earring: Claire gives this to Bender. It represents breaking down class barriers and showing true devotion.



A Varsity Patch: Allison takes this from Andrew's letterman jacket. It represents an outcast finally finding a connection.



An Essay: Brian writes a single letter for all of them. It represents defiance against unfair adult judgments and their newfound unity.

Watching Through a Modern Lens



Timeless Themes (The Good):

The film brilliantly captures adolescent pressure, the need for validation, and real mental health struggles.



Outdated Tropes (The Flaws):

Elements have not aged well, especially Bender's sexual harassment of Claire, and the cliché of Allison needing a makeover to be noticed by a boy.

Insight: We can appreciate a classic piece of art while still thinking critically about its flaws.

The Soundtrack of a Generation

The Anthem:

Simple Minds' hit song "Don't You (Forget About Me)" became a massive global hit and defined the 80s sound.



The Final Question:

The lyrics capture the film's anxious, hopeful ending. When Monday morning comes and they are back in the real world, will these new interesting heavens in the Hand, rrrrrh, will these new friends pretend they don't know each other?

Fact Check: True or False?

1. The students are happy to be spending Saturday in detention together.



(False)

2. Brian wrote a separate, individual essay for each of the five students.



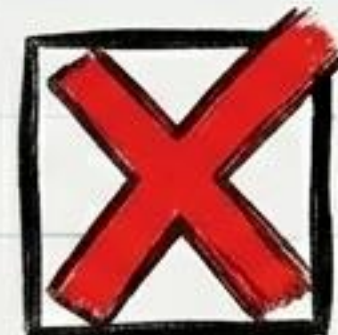
(False)

3. The actors improvised the emotional library confession scene.



(True)

4. The movie suggests that teenagers easily and openly communicate with their parents.



(False)

Memory Check: Fill in the Blanks

Q1. What is the main reason Brian was sent to detention?

Answer: He brought a flare gun to school due to extreme academic pressure.

Q2. How does the group sign the final essay they leave for the principal?

Answer: "The Breakfast Club"

Q3. Name three of the five labels the students use to describe themselves.

Answer: The Brain, The Athlete, The Basket Case, The Princess, The Criminal.

Your Turn to Speak

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Which character's hidden struggles did you relate to the most, and why?

Do high school cliques and extreme stereotypes still exist today in the same way they did in 1985?

Make a prediction: Do you think the characters stayed friends on Monday morning, or did they go back to their old groups?

?

Sincerely Yours...

**"You see us as you want
to see us: in the simplest
terms, in the most
convenient definitions."**

— The Breakfast Club



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